

Double FAULT

The candyfloss Sania Mirza-Shoaib Malik romance loses its sheen as Ayesha Siddiqui's claims of being married to the Pakistani cricketer are proved right

By Amarnath K. Menon

It should have been a cross-border fairytale romance, under wraps for months, then arriving at springtime in a burst of surprise. Then shock. Then scandal. Then sleaze. Within a week, it went from fairytale to airport bestseller to blotting-paper novel found at A.H. Wheeler's in a mofussil railway station. It featured Indian sport's diva Sania Mirza and Pakistan cricket's anti-hero Shoaib Malik. The marriage made for celebrity heaven turned into a sordid soap that some say enjoyed more

TRP ratings than the IPL matches for a while. This happened because a mystery woman from Malik's early life popped up like a net cord.

Ayesha Siddiqui's existence was known, her intrigue lay in how she was never seen, just heard, on television. Usually very shrill, whether shouting or weeping as she accused Malik of hiding the truth. Just when it looked like Malik had seized control of this bitter mismatch in a news conference, his new and far more glamorous fiancée at his side, came to the denouement. It not only knocked the issue out of the park but took with

it the former Pakistani captain's already flaky reputation.

The entity called Shoania was less Brangelina glamour and more ham scene from a Punjabi movie made in Malik's hometown Sialkot. It finally ended after 20 hours of negotiations and a written *talaq* signed by Malik. It was official recognition of Siddiqui's status as Malik's first wife. No prizes for guessing who's ranked No. 2.

This Track Two diplomacy took place not just between three families—the Mirzas and the Siddiquis, who live within two kilometres of each other, and the Maliks from hundreds



THE SANIA-SHOAIB ROMANCE HAS CAPTURED THE FANCY OF THE MEDIA